

PICKY EATER SOLUTION GUIDE

Food Exposure Log, Recipes & Mealtime Rules That Work

By Daniel Tesfamariam

WHY KIDS ARE PICKY (It's Normal!)

Picky eating peaks between ages 2-6. It's developmental, not defiance.

- Neophobia (fear of new) is a survival instinct
- Kids may need 15-20 exposures before accepting a new food
- Pressure and force ALWAYS backfire
- Division of responsibility: Parent decides WHAT and WHEN. Child decides IF and HOW MUCH.

MEALTIME RULES (Post at the Table)

1. You don't have to eat it. You DO have to sit with the family.
2. No 'yuck' or 'gross' - you can say 'no thank you'
3. New foods go on the 'explorer plate' (no pressure)
4. One safe food always served (bread, rice, fruit)
5. Meals last 20-30 minutes, then kitchen closes
6. No short-order cooking (one meal for everyone)
7. No screens at the table
8. Snacks are 2 hours before meals (not right before)

FOOD EXPOSURE LOG

Track each food exposure. Remember: seeing, smelling, and touching COUNT!

Goal: 15-20 exposures of each new food

FOOD: _____

Exposure 1: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 2: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 3: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 4: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 5: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

FOOD: _____

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Exposure 3: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 4: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

Exposure 5: Date ____/____ Reaction: []Refused []Touched []Smelled []Licked []Tasted []Ate!

SNEAK-IT-IN RECIPES

(Use ALONGSIDE open exposure, not as a replacement for it)

1. Hidden Veggie Pasta Sauce

Blend: 1 can tomatoes + 1 carrot + 1 zucchini + handful spinach

Cook: Simmer 20 min. Kids won't see or taste the veggies!

2. Smoothie Popsicles

Blend: banana + berries + yogurt + handful spinach (turns it green-purple)

Pour into molds. Kids eat veggies as a 'treat'!

3. Zucchini Muffins

Your favorite muffin recipe + 1 cup shredded zucchini. They dissolve!

4. Cauliflower Mac & Cheese

Steam cauliflower, blend into cheese sauce. Same taste, added nutrition.

5. Veggie Quesadillas

Finely diced peppers + beans + cheese in tortilla. Melted cheese hides veggies!

FOOD EXPLORATION ACTIVITIES

Making food FUN reduces fear. Try these with no eating pressure:

- Food art: make faces/pictures with fruit and veggies
- Grow it: plant herbs or tomatoes together
- Shop it: let child choose ONE new food to try
- Cook it: kids who help cook are more likely to eat
- Science it: 'What happens when we cook broccoli?'
- Rate it: blind taste tests with ratings (fun, not pressure)
- Build it: kebabs, wraps, pizza where THEY assemble
- Story it: read books about food and trying new things

ACCEPTED FOODS INVENTORY

List ALL foods your child currently accepts:

Proteins:

Grains/Starches:

Fruits:

Vegetables:

Dairy:

Snacks/Other:

Count: ____ foods accepted. Goal: Add 1-2 new foods per month.

WHEN TO SEEK HELP: Fewer than 20 accepted foods, weight loss, gagging/vomiting with textures = see a feeding therapist.

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Patience is the secret ingredient.